

Richard Girling, Ph.D.

Head of Growth Marketing | Healthcare Digital Marketing | Regulated D2C Acquisition

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PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

Growth marketing leader with 14 years of hands-on experience building and scaling patient-acquisition systems across 500+ US healthcare organisations. Founded and led Red Castle Services from inception to a 7-figure exit in 2026, developing the full acquisition stack - SEO, paid media, conversion-optimised landing pages, and lifecycle campaigns - in a category where clinical trust and regulatory compliance are the central conversion barriers. Comfortable operating as player-coach: defending strategy at board level and getting into GA4, ad accounts, or A/B test frameworks until the team is built. Ph.D. research in regulated entrepreneurial ecosystems sharpens analytical rigour and go-to-market thinking. Now bringing this experience to bear in UK mental health and neurodevelopmental care.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Growth Strategy & Funnel Optimisation	Paid Media (Google, Meta, LinkedIn)	SEO & Organic Acquisition
Patient / Consumer Acquisition at Scale	Regulated Healthcare Marketing	Conversion Rate Optimisation
Agency Management & Accountability	Analytics (GA4, HubSpot, Mixpanel)	Mental Health Marketing
A/B Testing & Experimentation	Content & Thought Leadership	D2C Campaign Architecture

EXPERIENCE

Founder & CEO

Red Castle Services · Full-time · May 2012 - May 2026 (14 years)

- Built a specialist healthcare digital marketing agency from zero to 500+ active medical practice clients across the United States, delivering full-stack growth services - SEO, Google Ads, Meta campaigns, web design, and conversion optimisation - within the highly regulated US healthcare environment (HIPAA, FTC, state medical board advertising rules).
- Designed and scaled a branded acquisition model built on strong clinical credibility: landing page frameworks, keyword architecture, and patient-journey funnels that consistently outperformed generic agency benchmarks, driving measurable new-patient volume for clients across primary care, orthopaedics, aesthetics, and specialist mental health practices - including psychologists and psychiatrists - where trust is the primary conversion barrier.
- Grew company revenue to a 7-figure exit in 2026; managed agency partnerships, an in-house team, and performance reporting across a large client portfolio simultaneously - demonstrating the player-coach operating model the ProblemShared role demands.
- Operated at the intersection of clinical trust and commercial growth: all campaigns required compliance with advertising standards for medical services, directly analogous to ASA/CAP/MHRA requirements in the UK regulated healthcare context.
- Key metrics ownership: CAC, LTV:CAC ratios, channel-level ROAS, organic traffic growth, and conversion rates from landing page to booked appointment - building an attribution-literate performance culture from the outset.

Strategic Advisor & Venture Partner

Girling Strategic Advisors · May 2026 - Present

- Providing fractional growth advisory to HealthTech and impact-focused scale-ups: implementing AI-driven SEO systems, paid acquisition strategies, and go-to-market frameworks for D2C and B2B2C propositions.
- Conducting due diligence for VC investors on the commercial viability of early-stage healthcare and tech ventures, drawing on deep understanding of growth economics and regulated market dynamics.
- Board advisory to early-stage companies: governance, commercial strategy, and founder accountability.

Head of Communications

Migration Policy Group · Full-time · Sep 2021 - Dec 2022

- Designed and implemented global communications strategy and digital infrastructure for an international policy advocacy organisation operating across highly regulated, multi-stakeholder environments.
- Built systems to influence policy audiences and manage international advocacy networks - developing skills in trust-based messaging and audience segmentation directly applicable to mental health brand communications.

Doctoral Researcher

University of Amsterdam · Part-time · Sep 2017 - Sep 2021

- Conducted 70+ in-depth interviews with founders across 20+ countries to understand how structural and social factors drive entrepreneurial success in regulated and cross-border environments.
- Research provided the analytical framework underpinning GTM advisory and commercial decision-making - a rigorous, evidence-based lens applied to growth strategy.

Communications Consultant

Helsinki Foundation for Human Rights · Aug 2020 - Aug 2021

- Digital consultancy on nonprofit CRM strategy, donation page optimisation, and digital campaign design - applying commercial growth principles to mission-driven conversion contexts.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Entrepreneurship & Entrepreneurial Studies

University of Amsterdam · 2017-2021

Research: data-driven frameworks for evaluating social capital and scalability in diverse founder ecosystems.

Master's Degree, International Relations

University of Wroclaw · 2014-2016

BA German & Linguistics (1st Class Honours)

Durham University · 2002-2006

CERTIFICATIONS

- Sequence Models - DeepLearning.AI (Feb 2026)
- Structuring Machine Learning Projects - DeepLearning.AI (Feb 2026)

ADDITIONAL

Regulatory awareness: Extensive practical experience in US healthcare advertising compliance (HIPAA, FTC, state medical board rules). Working knowledge of UK regulated marketing frameworks (ASA, CAP Code, MHRA); committed to rapid upskilling on CQC-specific requirements.

Tools: Google Ads, Meta Ads Manager, GA4, HubSpot, SEMrush/Ahrefs, Mixpanel, Figma (basic), AI-assisted content and SEO tooling.

Languages: English (native), German (professional), Polish (conversational).

Peer-reviewed publications: Available at scholar.google.com/citations?user=93YGWNwAAAAJ